

The War for a Continent: How the French and Indian War Forged America's Path

A Story of Empires, Alliances, and
the Fight for the Ohio Valley



A Global Game of Empires

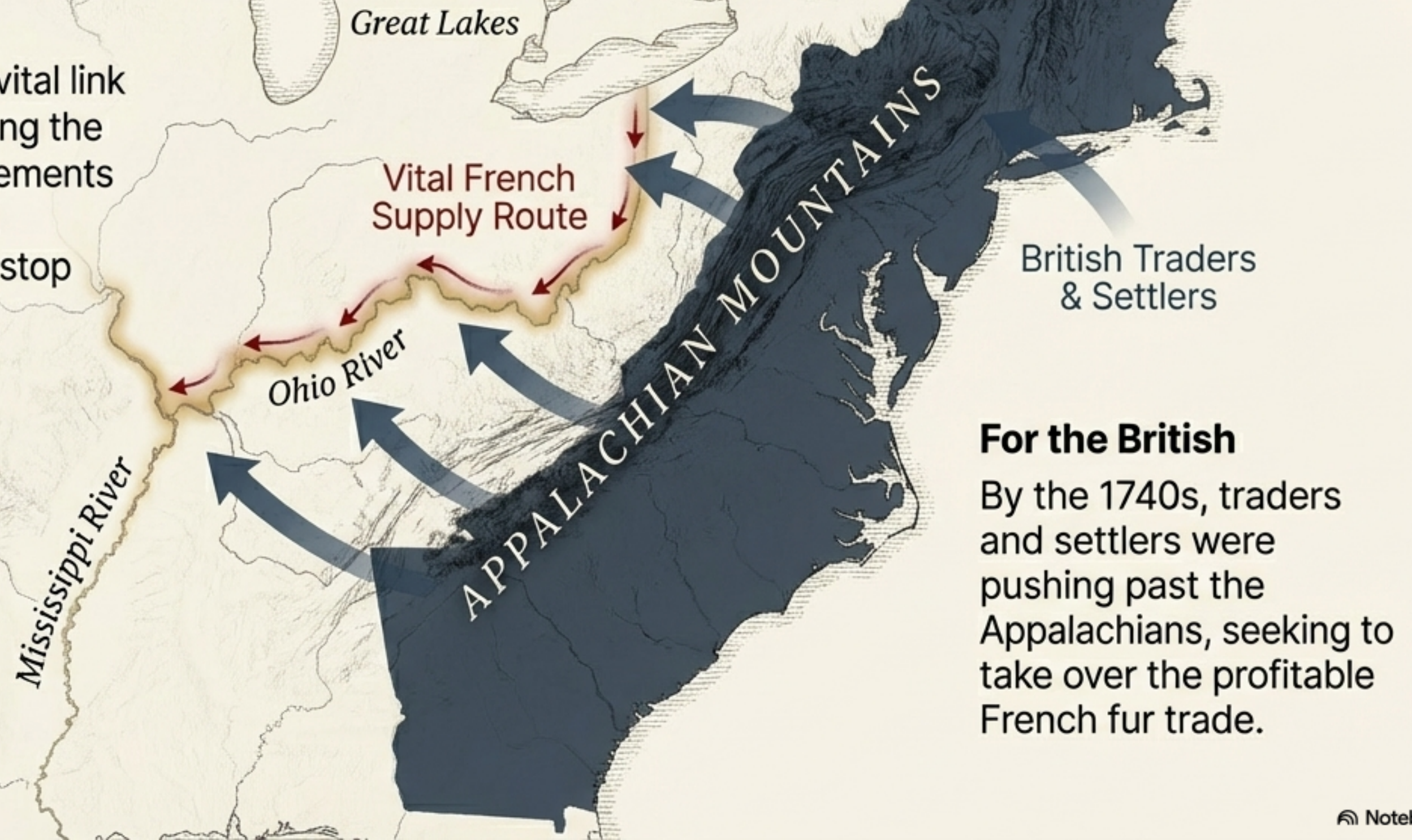
- By the mid-1700s, Britain, France, Spain, and the Netherlands were locked in a worldwide struggle for empire, competing for trade and colonies.
- In North America, the most serious threat to the British colonies came from France, which claimed a vast territory circling the English settlements.



The Ohio Valley: A Strategic Linchpin

For the French

The Ohio River provided a vital link between French claims along the Great Lakes and their settlements along the Mississippi River. France was determined to stop British expansion.



For the British

By the 1740s, traders and settlers were pushing past the Appalachians, seeking to take over the profitable French fur trade.

“The Two Edges of a Pair of Shears”

“You and the French are like the two edges of a pair of shears. And we are the cloth which is to be cut to pieces between them.”

– A Native American protest to a British trader

French Allies (Algonquins, Hurons)

- Mostly trappers and traders.
- Did not clear forests for farms.
- Often intermarried and adopted Native American ways.



British Allies (Iroquois Nations)

- Attracted by lower prices for trade goods.
- Forged by official William Johnson, who had an Indian wife, Molly Brant.
- Capitalized on the Iroquois' traditional enmity with the Algonquin and Huron.



The Virginian's First Test

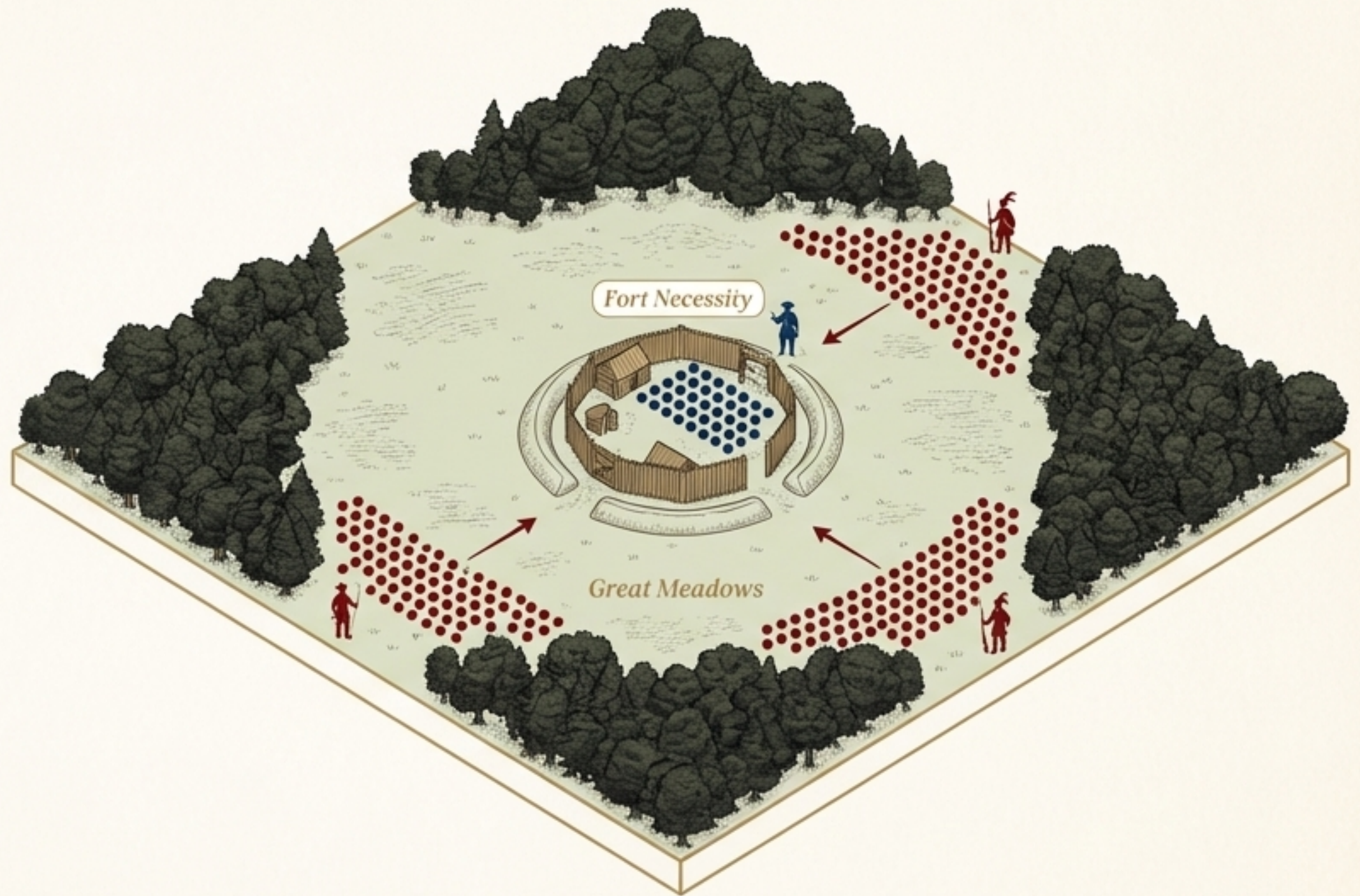
George Washington

- **Age:** 22
- **Background:** Son of wealthy Virginia planters; skilled land surveyor familiar with the western frontier.
- **The Mission (1753):** Sent by Virginia's governor to deliver a letter demanding French withdrawal from the Ohio Valley. The French refused.
- **The Follow-up (1754):** Ordered to build a fort at the junction of the Monongahela and Allegheny rivers (modern-day Pittsburgh).



A Volley That Set the World in Flames

1. **French Preemption:** Washington learns the French have already built Fort Duquesne at his target location.
2. **Surprise Attack:** Guided by Indian allies, Washington launches a successful surprise attack on a camp of French scouts.
3. **Fort Necessity:** Hearing of a French counterattack, his men build a makeshift stockade named Fort Necessity.
4. **Surrender:** A force of 700 French and Indians surrounds the fort. Badly outnumbered, Washington and his 150 men surrender.



"The volley fired by this young Virginian in the forests of America has set the world in flames."

- Horace Walpole, British writer

A Union Demanded, A Union Denied

The Albany Plan of Union

- **Proponent:** Benjamin Franklin, delegate from Pennsylvania.
- **Goals:** To create “one general government” for the colonies to plan a united defense and cement the Iroquois alliance.
- **Proposal:** A Grand Council with representatives from each colony to make laws, raise taxes, and manage defense.
- **Outcome:** Accepted by the delegates, but rejected by every single colonial assembly. None would give up power to a central authority.



“Everyone cries a union is necessary. But when they come to the manner and form of the union, their weak noodl perfectly distracted.”
– Benjamin Franklin

Braddock's Gamble: A March into the Wilderness



- **The Commander:** General Edward Braddock. A stubborn man who had little experience at fighting in the forests of North America.
- **The Mission (1755):** Lead British and colonial troops to capture Fort Duquesne.
- **The Boast:** Confidently predicted he would "sweep the French from the Ohio Valley."



Disaster on the Monongahela

The Ambush: As the British neared Fort Duquesne, French and Indian forces launched a surprise attack from the forest.



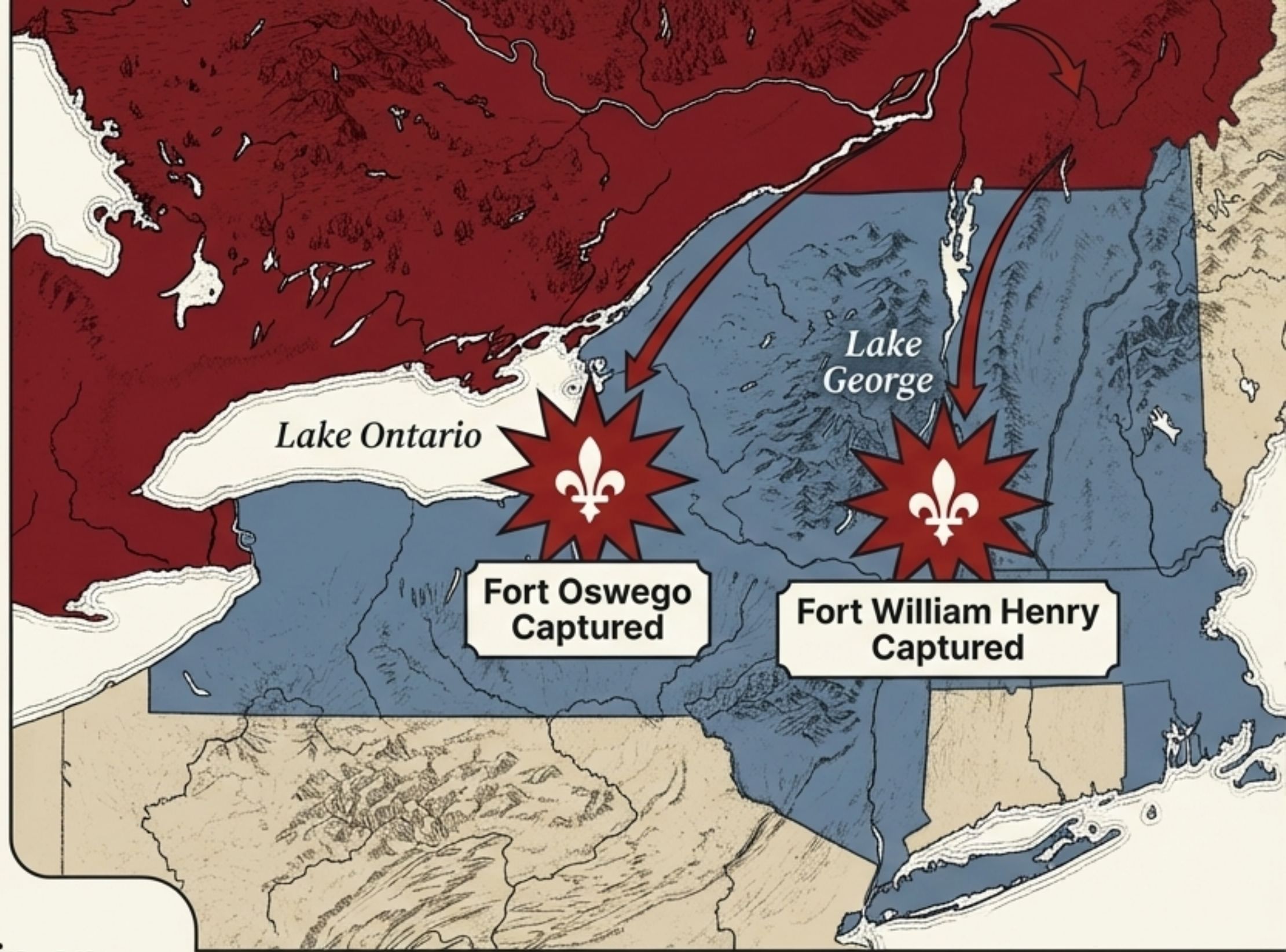
Tactical Mismatch: Sharpshooters hid and picked off British soldiers. The British soldiers' bright red uniforms made them easy targets.

The Aftermath: General Braddock had five horses shot from under him before being fatally wounded. Almost half of the British force was killed or wounded. George Washington was nearly killed.

The British Under Siege: 1755-1757

A String of Defeats:

The war continued to go badly for the British after Braddock's disaster.



These defeats put a serious strain on:

These defeats put a serious strain on the alliance with the Iroquois, who had counted on British protection and now faced increasing danger from enemy tribes.

The Pitt Doctrine: A New Strategy for Victory



The Architect: William Pitt, the new Prime Minister of Great Britain (1757).

Pitt's Strategy:

- ◆ **Priority One:** Make winning the war in North America his first job. He argued that victory there would enable victory elsewhere in the world.
- ◆ **Resources:** Sent Britain's best generals to North America.
- ◆ **Incentives:** Promised large payments to the colonies for military services and supplies to encourage their support.

The Tide Turns: A Cascade of British Victories

The Results of Pitt's Leadership

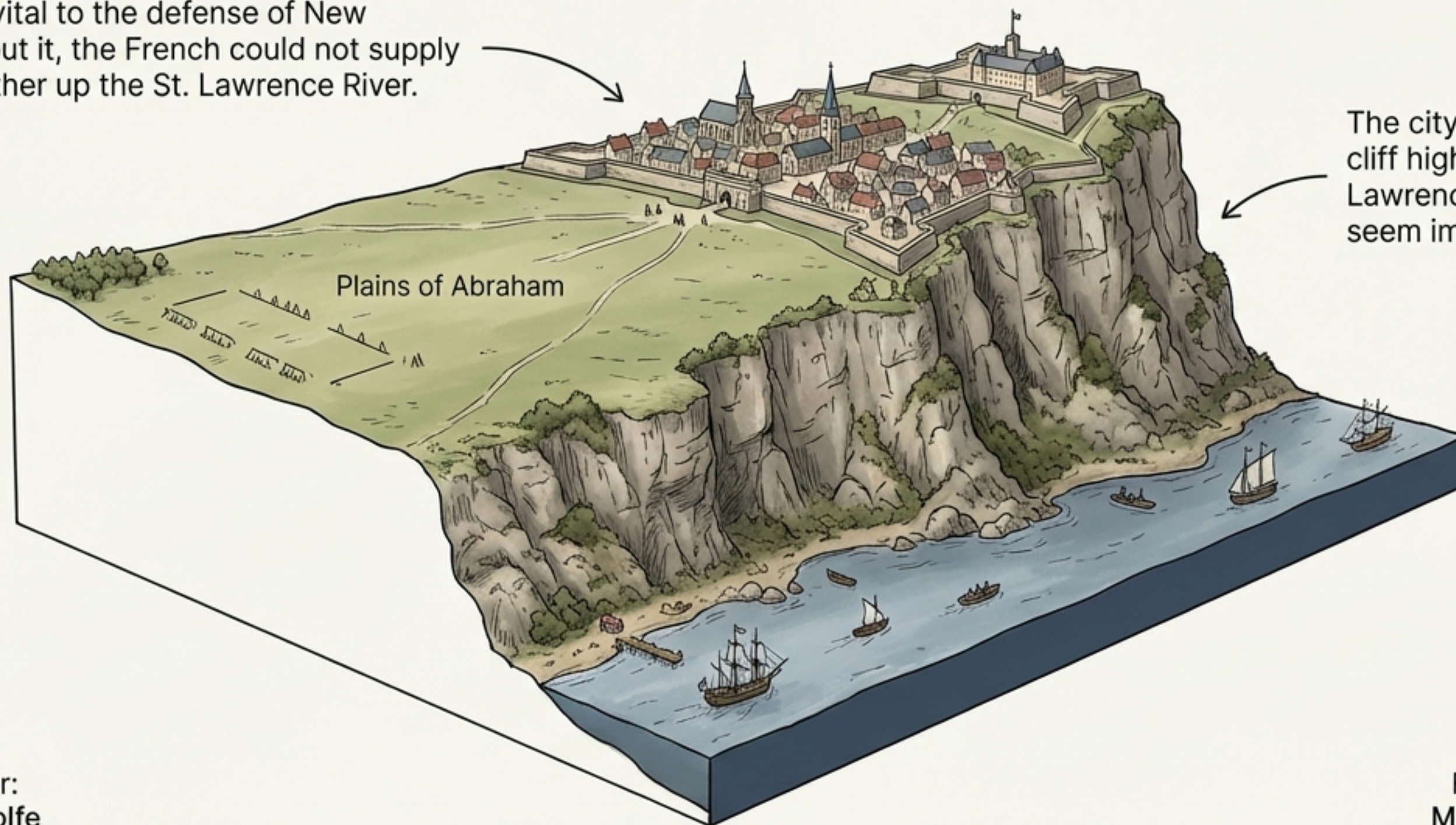
- 1758: Major General Jeffrey Amherst captures Louisbourg, the most important fort in French Canada.
- 1758: The British seize Fort Duquesne and rename it Fort Pitt.
- 1759: French are pushed from Fort Niagara, Crown Point, and Fort Ticonderoga.



The Ultimate Prize: The Battle for Quebec

Quebec was vital to the defense of New France. Without it, the French could not supply their forts farther up the St. Lawrence River.

The city sat atop a steep cliff high above the St. Lawrence, making it seem impregnable.



British Commander:
General James Wolfe



French Commander:
Marquis de Montcalm

The Plains of Abraham: A Single Morning Decides a Continent

Wolfe's Bold Plan

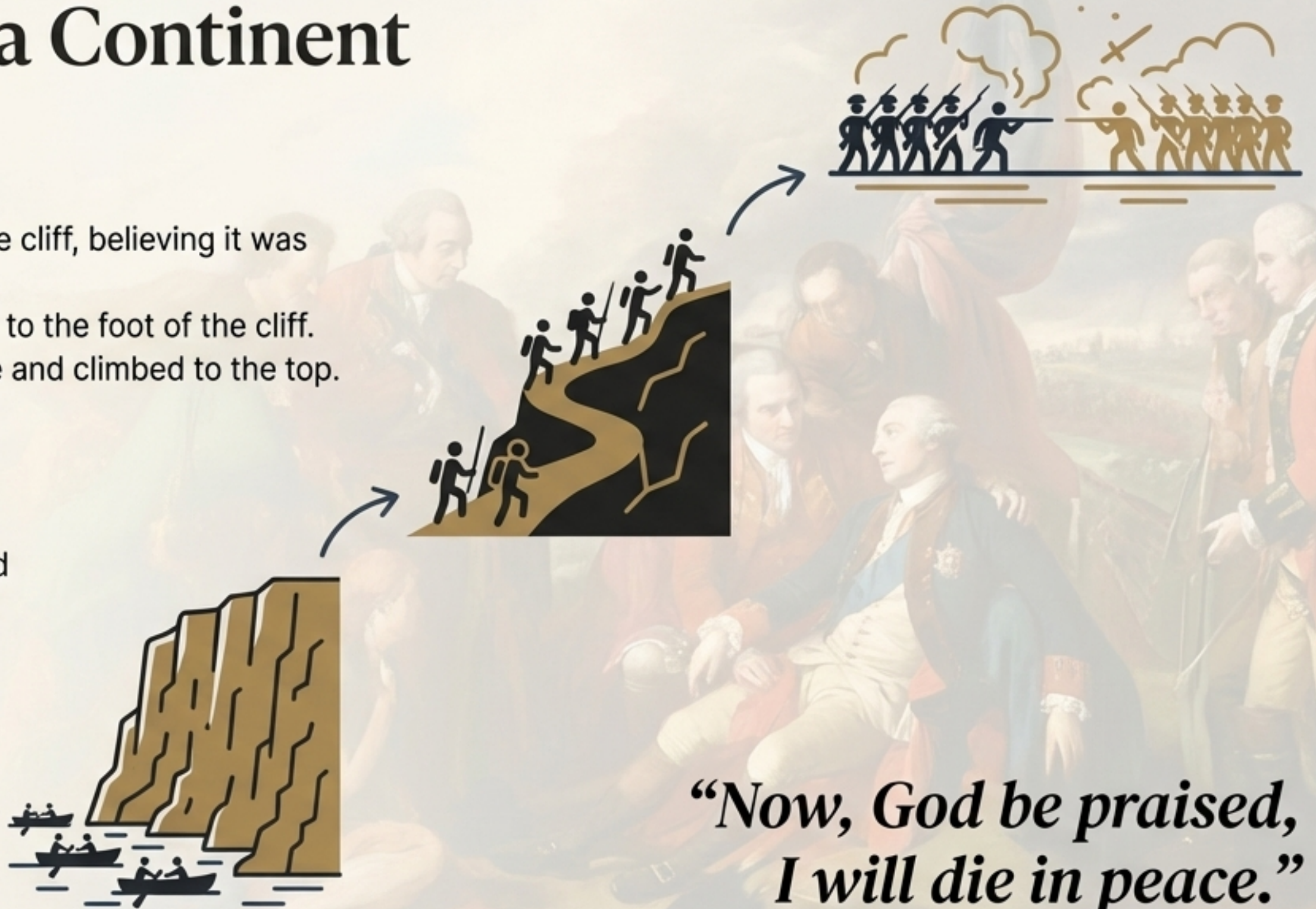
- He knew Montcalm had few guards on the cliff, believing it was too steep to climb.
- Late at night, British troops rowed quietly to the foot of the cliff.
- In darkness, the soldiers swarmed ashore and climbed to the top.

The Battle

- The next morning, Montcalm was stunned to find 4,000 British troops assembled on the Plains of Abraham.
- He marched his troops out to fight. A fierce battle ensued.

The Cost of Victory

- Both Montcalm and Wolfe were killed.



A New Map for North America

North America in 1754



North America in 1763



The Treaty of Paris (1763)

The peace treaty that officially ended the war. It marked the end of French power in North America.

Territorial Changes

- **Britain Gained:** Canada and all French lands east of the Mississippi River (except New Orleans). Florida from Spain.
 - **Spain Gained:** All French land west of the Mississippi River, plus New Orleans.
- **France Kept:** Two small islands in the Gulf of St. Lawrence and its sugar islands in the West Indies.

"Peace returned to North America. Yet, in a few short years, a new conflict would break out. This time, the struggle would pit Britain against its own 13 colonies."